



High-wheelers

Early bicycles were powered by the **front wheel**, so its size limited how fast they could go. Thrill-seekers solved the problem by making bikes with enormous front wheels—some were **5 ft (1.5 m)** across—and a much smaller rear wheel. Daredevil riders perched precariously over the front wheel and **WHIZZED ALONG** at high speeds, to the alarm of passersby.

How it changed the world

Before bicycles, you needed a horse if you wanted to get anywhere in a hurry. Bikes speed people to their destinations without anyone cleaning up after them. They convert human power into movement more efficiently than anything else.

Today, there are twice as many bicycles as cars.



Safety bikes

Perilous penny-farthings were replaced by **safety bicycles** in the 1880s. They were driven by a rear-wheel chain, so the wheels could be of **equal size**. Things got even better for cyclists with the invention of air-filled tires, gears, safety reflectors, and generator-powered headlights. **LIGHTER AND MORE EFFICIENT** bicycle models continue to be developed.



THE TANDEM is an unusual bicycle that allows two riders to sit one in front of the other and cycle **SIMULTANEOUSLY**.



BICYCLE RACING is a popular **MODERN SPORT**, with many different events for different types of bicycles raced over various distances.